

Yoga for Arthritis: Gentle Poses That Help

A guide to gentle yoga poses recommended for arthritis. Improve flexibility, reduce stiffness and manage pain naturally.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Yoga for Arthritis: Gentle, Evidence-Based Relief



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Yoga combines gentle stretching, strengthening, and mindfulness — making it one of the most holistic approaches to arthritis management. NICE recognises yoga as a beneficial activity for people with chronic pain.

What the Research Shows

A 2019 systematic review of 17 studies found yoga: - Reduced joint pain by 22% (moderate evidence) - Improved physical function by 20% - Decreased stiffness by 18% - Enhanced mental wellbeing and reduced depression - Was safe with no serious adverse events reported

8 Gentle Yoga Poses for Arthritis



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1. Mountain Pose (Tadasana) Stand tall, feet hip-width apart. Ground through your feet, lengthen your spine. Hold 30 seconds. ****Benefits:**** Improves posture and body awareness

2. Cat-Cow Stretch On hands and knees, alternate between arching (cow) and rounding (cat) your spine. ****Benefits:**** Mobilises the entire spine, reduces stiffness

3. Warrior II (Modified) Wide stance, front knee bent (not past ankle), arms extended. Use a chair if needed. ****Benefits:**** Strengthens legs, opens hips

4. Seated Twist Sit tall in a chair. Place your right hand on your left knee, gently twist left. Hold 15 seconds each side. ****Benefits:**** Spinal mobility, reduces back stiffness



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5. Bridge Pose Lie on your back, knees bent. Slowly lift hips, hold 10 seconds. Lower slowly. ****Benefits:**** Strengthens glutes and core, supports hip and knee joints

6. Child's Pose Kneel, sit back on heels (use a cushion if needed), extend arms forward. ****Benefits:**** Gentle back stretch, calming

7. Legs Up the Wall Lie on your back with legs resting up a wall. Relax for 3–5 minutes.

****Benefits:**** Reduces swelling in legs and feet, deeply relaxing

8. Corpse Pose (Savasana) Lie flat, arms by sides, eyes closed. Focus on breathing for

5 minutes. ****Benefits:**** Activates parasympathetic nervous system, reduces pain perception

Yoga Tips for Arthritis

- ****Use props freely**** — blocks, straps, blankets, and bolsters reduce strain
- ****Chair yoga**** is excellent if getting to the floor is difficult
- ****Never push through pain**** — modify or skip any pose that causes sharp pain
- ****Warm up first**** — gentle joint circles before poses
- ****Practice regularly**** — 15–20 minutes daily is better than one long session

Finding the Right Class

- Look for "gentle yoga", "restorative yoga", or "yoga for arthritis" classes
- Many studios and NHS physiotherapy departments offer adapted classes
- Online options: Yoga with Adriene (free YouTube), Versus Arthritis yoga videos

Written by Anna Stevens, Yoga Therapist and HCPC Registered Physiotherapist

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about yoga for arthritis: gentle poses that help?

Short answer: Yoga for arthritis can reduce joint pain by 22% and improve physical function by 20%, according to a 2019 review of 17 studies. Gentle poses like Mountain Pose, Cat-Cow, and Seated Twist improve posture, spinal mobility, and reduce stiffness. Always use props, avoid pushing through pain, and warm up gently before practising for 15-20 minutes daily.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk